The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Dependent Origination

Āryapratītyasamutpādanāmamahāyānasūtra · Toh 980 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་རྟེན་ཅིང་འབྲེལ་བར་འབྱུང་བ་ཞེས་བྱ་བ་ཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པོའི་མདོ།

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Dependent Origination, known in Sanskrit as the Āryapratītyasamutpādanāmamahāyānasūtra and in Tibetan as Phags pa rten cing 'brel bar 'byung ba zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo, is a brief Mahāyāna sūtra. It is set in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, where the Buddha is joined by great śrāvakas such as Aśvajit, by bodhisattvas including Maitreya, Avalokiteśvara, and Vajrapāṇi, and by gods such as Brahmā, Śiva, and Indra. In this setting a bodhisattva puts a question to the Buddha, and the discourse that follows centers on the teaching of dependent origination. That teaching is presented in its well-known verse form, which is widely recited and enshrined as a sacred formula, particularly in connection with stūpas and the merit of honoring them. The text is Toh 980 in the Kangyur, where it is included among the collected dhāraṇīs, reflecting the use of its central verse as a formula of power and blessing.

In the language of India: ārya pratītya samutpada nāma mahāyāna sūtra
In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Dependent Origination.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling in the abode of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, on a stone slab like armonika. With him were the great śrāvakas, such as the venerable Aśvajit. There were also the bodhisattva great beings adorned with immeasurable precious qualities, such as the noble Maitreya, the noble Avalokiteśvara, and Vajrapāṇi. There were the gods, such as Mahābrahmā, lord of the Sahā world, Nārāyaṇa, and Maheśvara (Śiva). And there were Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, Pañcaśikha, king of the gandharvas, and others.

Then the bodhisattva great being Avalokiteśvara rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, and planted his right knee on the summit of Mount Meru. Bowing with palms joined toward the Blessed One, he addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, these gods all wish to build stūpas. Since they are present here in this assembly, may the Blessed One please teach them the Dharma in such

a way that the merit of Brahmā increases, and that, in the world with its gods, māras, and Brahmās, and among beings with their śramaṇas and brahmins, the monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen will increase their merit exceedingly."

When he had made this request, the Blessed One then spoke the verse of dependent origination:

ye dharmā hetu prabhavā hehunteṣāṃ tathāgato hyabdat teṣāñca yo nirodha evaṃ vādī mahāśramaṇaḥ

Whatever phenomena arise from causes,
Their cause, and whatever their cessation is,
The Tathāgata has declared;
Thus has the Great Śramaṇa spoken.

"Avalokiteśvara, it is like this: this dependent origination is the dharmakāya of the tathāgatas. Whoever sees dependent origination sees the Tathāgata.

"Avalokiteśvara, if any son or daughter of good family who has faith builds, in an uninhabited place, a stūpa only the size of a myrobalan fruit, with a central axis only the size of a needle and a parasol only the size of a bakula flower, and places within it the dharmadhātu verse of dependent origination, that person will generate the merit of Brahmā. After passing away from here and dying, they will be reborn in the world of Brahmā."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, those śrāvakas, those bodhisattvas, that entire assembly, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This concludes the Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called Dependent Origination.

Translator's Notes

• The stone slab is described as being "like armonika." This appears to refer to the Pāṇḍukambala stone seat of Indra in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, which is traditionally likened to a white woolen blanket. The exact sense of "armonika" is uncertain, so the word has been kept as it stands. "The merit of Brahmā" (brāhma puṇya) is a technical expression for an exceptionally great merit, the kind that leads to birth in the Brahmā world. "Dharmadhātu verse of dependent origination" renders the Tibetan literally. The verse itself is so called because it expresses the nature of reality.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.